Is Wigan's crime high?

An analysis of police recorded crime in the Wigan borough, 2020/21 to 2025/26, with tests against deprivation and forecasts to 2030/31

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Code, data pipeline and saved models: https://github.com/dynamixAI/wigan-crime-analysis

Data: Home Office police recorded crime (Community Safety Partnership open data tables, release of 22 October 2026); ONS mid-year population estimates; English Indices of Deprivation 2025. Contains public sector information licensed under the Open Government Licence v3.0.

In one sentence: Wigan's recorded crime rate is about 9% above the England and Wales average, but that is largely what you would expect for a large urban borough with its level of deprivation. Among England's 36 metropolitan boroughs it is close to typical, it is the third lowest of Greater Manchester's ten boroughs, and it has been falling faster than the national rate.

Executive summary

This report asks a simple question that turns out to need careful handling: **is crime in Wigan high?** A raw comparison with the national average says yes. Each fairer comparison, controlling for deprivation and then for the kind of place Wigan is, shrinks that gap. The answer the evidence supports is that Wigan is close to typical for a place like it.

Key findings

- **Level.** In 2024/25, the latest year with reliable borough figures, Wigan recorded 91.9 crimes per 1,000 residents (excluding fraud): 9% above England and Wales (84.6), 13% below the Greater Manchester average (106.2) and 9% below Bolton (101.1). Wigan ranks 8th of Greater Manchester's 10 boroughs, the 3rd lowest.
- **Trend.** Wigan's rate fell 18% from its 2021/22 peak (112.1) to 2024/25, against a 4% fall nationally. Part of the earlier rise reflects Greater Manchester Police (GMP) improving how it records crime after a 2020 inspection.
- **Type.** Wigan has more violence (+26%), public order offences (+48%) and criminal damage (+24%) than the national average, and less theft (−28%) and robbery (−31%). Violence and public order are the categories most affected by police recording practice.
- **Compared like with like.** Against areas with similar income deprivation, Wigan looks 8–13% higher than expected. But against England's 36 metropolitan boroughs only, the gap falls to +5% (12th of 36), and Wigan's raw rate is below the metropolitan median (98.3). The largest differences between places follow police force boundaries.
- **A data gap.** GMP has not supplied street-level crime data to police.uk since July 2019. In addition, the share of GMP crimes with no borough recorded rose from 0.7% in 2024/25 to 84% by April–June 2026, so official borough figures from 2025/26 onwards are understated. The release notes do not mention this for Greater Manchester.
- **Forecast.** A Holt-Winters model trained only on data to March 2025 predicted GMP's 2025/26 total to within 3.4%, closer than the published borough figures (6.0% short). For Wigan, the central forecast is 90.6 crimes per 1,000 in 2026/27 (range 88–93) and 88.4 in 2027/28 (82–95). Beyond two years, results are presented as scenarios only.

Measure (crimes per 1,000, excl. fraud)	Wigan	Comparison	Difference
2024/25 vs England and Wales	91.9	84.6	+9%
2024/25 vs Greater Manchester	91.9	106.2	−13%
2024/25 vs Bolton (control borough)	91.9	101.1	−9%
vs expected for its income deprivation (all English areas)	92.5	85.8	+8%
vs expected, 36 metropolitan boroughs only	92.5	88.0	+5%
2025/26 estimate vs England and Wales	89.5–90.7	82.9	+8–9%
Forecast 2026/27 (range)	90.6 (88–93)	–	–

Table 1. Headline figures. The 2024/25 deprivation comparison uses Wigan's rate after sharing out GMP's 0.7% unassigned crimes (92.5).

1. Introduction

1.1 The public debate

Residents often say they feel unsafe in parts of Wigan town centre at certain times, and that view is reflected in local coverage. A Wigan Today columnist wrote in 2023 that "*Wigan is a crime hotspot. It's unsafe.*" [1] The same month, councillors raised concerns that daytime drinking and anti-social behaviour around the bus station were deterring families from the town centre [2]. More recent incidents have kept the issue in the news: two people were stabbed at Wigan bus station in September 2025, after which police issued a dispersal order. Police said: "*Anti-social behaviour and violence have no place in our town centre.*" [3] In May 2026, a man was injured, apparently by a knife, during a disturbance on Market Street [4]. Police list violent crime, anti-social behaviour and the town centre night-time economy among their 2026 priorities for central Wigan [5], and Wigan Council is consulting on renewing its town centre public space protection orders [6].

Published figures point in different directions. In February 2026, Wigan Today reported a 5% fall in recorded crime in the year to September 2025 [11], and GMP reported that residential burglary fell 24% and personal robbery 21% across Wigan and Leigh in 2025, with its local inspector stating that officers were "*responding faster, solving more crimes*" [10]. Three months later, Wigan Today reported a rise in recorded crime and noted that Wigan recorded the second-highest number of crimes in Greater Manchester [9]. Reports like these usually describe counts over short periods. This analysis uses rates per resident over six years, and compares them fairly.

1.2 Questions and approach

This analysis tests whether recorded crime supports the view that Wigan has a high crime rate, using only public data so that anyone can check it. It answers four questions:

- **Q1.** How does Wigan's recorded crime rate compare with its neighbours, Greater Manchester and the national average, and how is it changing?
- **Q2.** Which types of crime drive any difference?
- **Q3.** Is any difference explained by the kind of place Wigan is: its deprivation and its urban character?
- **Q4.** What is likely to happen next, and how far ahead can that be forecast honestly?

Two principles run through the method. First, **compare rates, not counts**: every comparison uses crimes per 1,000 residents, because larger places always have more crimes. Second, **test the conclusion, not just the data**: each finding was challenged with a fairer comparison, and the report shows how the answer changed at each step.

1.3 What this analysis cannot do

The data is borough-level and quarterly. It cannot say anything about specific streets, the town centre, or particular times of day, because GMP does not publish street-level data (section 2.1). Recorded crime also differs from crime that actually happens: it depends on what people report and how police record it. The report is careful to separate these.

2. Data

2.1 Why the obvious source could not be used

The usual source for local crime analysis is police.uk, which publishes street-level crimes through an open API. An initial analysis used it, and produced misleading results for two reasons:

- **GMP stopped supplying police.uk in July 2019.** In a 2026 Freedom of Information response (ref. 26.016219) [7], GMP confirmed it "hasn't provided data to police.uk since July 2019" and has no timeline to resume. Querying the API for the whole Wigan boundary returned only 5–17 crimes a month, against several thousand actually recorded. Of the 381 records returned over three years, 96 were British Transport Police railway crimes.
- **An earlier notebook built on the API contained errors that were invisible without this context:** every record appeared three times (all counts were divisible by three), the data came from a 1-mile radius around a single point rather than the whole borough, and inside Greater Manchester it was mostly railway crime.

This is worth stating because anyone checking Wigan's crime on police.uk today would find almost nothing, and could wrongly conclude crime is very low.

2.2 Crime data used

The analysis uses the Home Office *Police recorded crime Community Safety Partnership open data tables* (year ending March 2021 to year ending June 2026; updated 22 October 2026) [8]. These are the same figures the ONS uses in its official *Crime in England and Wales* statistics. Every police force, including GMP, must report them to the Home Office.

Property	Detail	Why it matters
Coverage	Every Community Safety Partnership (CSP) in England and Wales	All comparison areas come from one consistent source
Geography	CSP, which matches the local authority (Wigan CSP = Wigan borough)	Borough-level rates can be matched to population
Time	Quarterly, by financial year (April–March)	Seasonality can be modelled
Detail	Offence group, subgroup and 144 offence types	Crime mix can be compared
Format	Long format: one row per area, quarter and offence type	Already tidy; 1.24 million rows in total
Licence	Open Government Licence v3.0	Free to reuse and publish

The release was converted from ODS to one CSV per financial year with LibreOffice (about three minutes), which is much faster and lighter than reading a 50 MB spreadsheet directly in pandas.

2.3 Definitions

- **Fraud is excluded.** Since 2011–2013, fraud has been recorded centrally by Action Fraud rather than local police, so it is largely missing at local level and would distort borough comparisons [19].
- **Anti-social behaviour is not included.** It is not a notifiable crime and is not in these tables.
- **Greater Manchester** means the whole of GMP's recorded crime, including crimes with no borough recorded and Manchester Airport, so that it is never understated.

2.4 Population and deprivation

Population: ONS mid-year population estimates from Nomis (dataset NM_2002_1) [18], mid-2020 to mid-2025, for the 10 Greater Manchester boroughs and England and Wales, and mid-2024 for all 296 English local authorities. The mid-year estimate for year N (30 June) falls inside financial year N/N+1, so mid-2024 population is used for 2024/25 crime.

Deprivation: English Indices of Deprivation 2025 (File 10, version 2, the corrected release) [17]. The analysis uses the **income domain**, the share of residents on low incomes, not the overall Index of Multiple Deprivation. The overall index includes a *crime* domain, so using it to explain crime would be circular. The index covers England only.

2.5 Data quality checks

Before any modelling, the data was checked for the problems that most often break analyses of this kind.

Check	Result	Action
Counts that are not numbers	0 of 1,243,788 rows	None needed
Negative counts (row level)	1 row	None: explained in the release notes (cancelled or transferred crimes); disappears on aggregation
Missing borough-quarters, 2021/22–2024/25	160 of 160 present	None: no gaps to fill
Zero or negative borough-quarters	0	None
Outliers	Each borough within about ±15% of its own average	None: normal seasonal and yearly variation
Crimes with no borough recorded	0.3–0.7% to 2024/25; then rising sharply	See section 3

3. A data problem: crimes with no borough

When GMP records a crime it is normally tagged with the borough where it happened. Crimes without a location appear under a catch-all area, *Unassigned Greater Manchester*. This was routinely below 1% of GMP's crime. From the second half of 2025 it rose sharply.

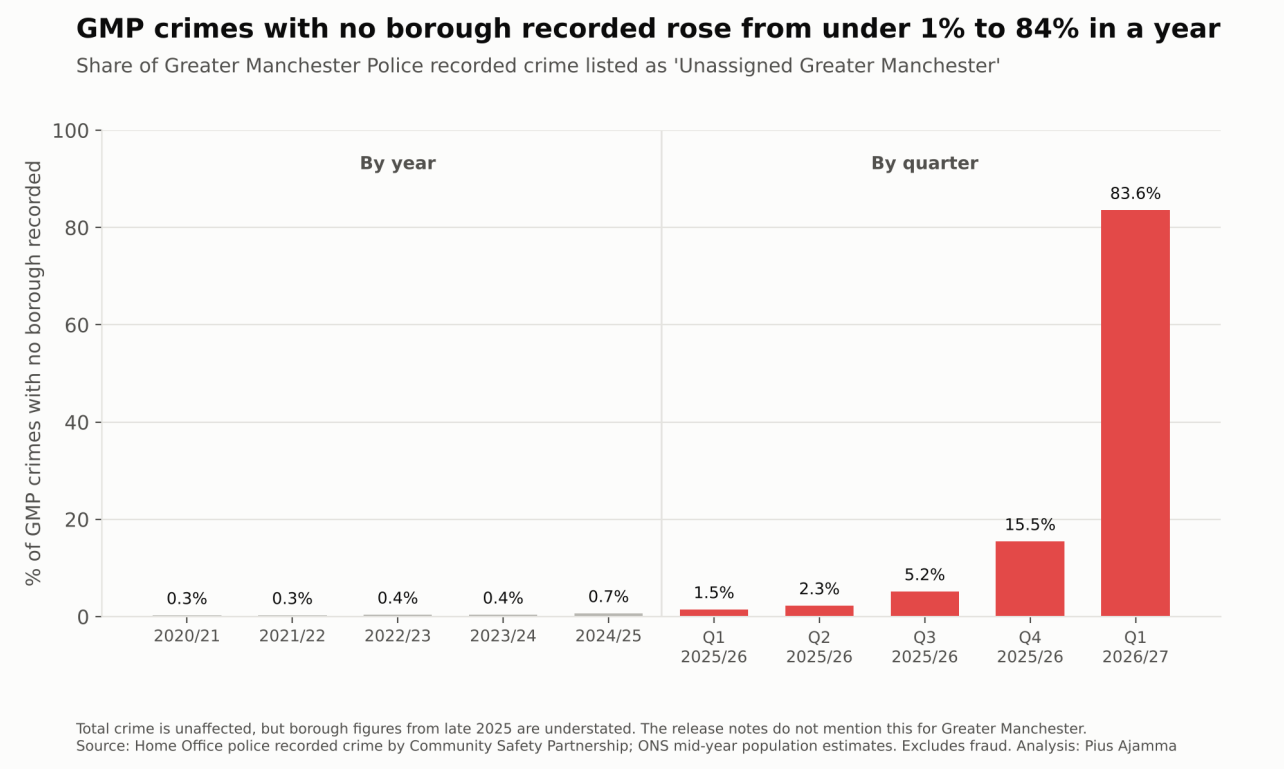


Figure 1. Share of GMP recorded crime with no borough recorded, by year and then by quarter.

Period	GMP total (excl. fraud)	Unassigned	Share
2020/21	273,382	946	0.3%
2021/22	351,488	943	0.3%
2022/23	371,708	1,405	0.4%
2023/24	342,139	1,413	0.4%
2024/25	318,627	2,287	0.7%
2025/26	311,748	18,499	5.9%
2026/27 Q1 (Apr–Jun 2026)	81,052	67,773	83.6%

Table 2. GMP crimes with no borough recorded.

GMP's total stayed steady at about 81,000 crimes a quarter, so **crime did not fall: crimes stopped being linked to a borough**. Every borough's published figure shrinks, by different amounts (in January–March 2026, Wigan lost 19% and Bolton 8%), so rankings for that period are also distorted. The release notes describe similar problems in Kent and Humberside, but not Greater Manchester. The cause is not known; a change in GMP's systems or location coding is plausible but unconfirmed.

How it was handled

- **Reliability rule:** a year is used for borough comparison only if no more than 2% of GMP's crimes are unassigned. This makes **2024/25 the latest reliable year**.
- **2025/26 estimate:** unassigned crimes were shared out to each borough in proportion to its recorded crimes, and labelled as an estimate. An independent forecast (section 6) was used to check it.
- **2026/27 Q1** was excluded from all borough-level analysis.

4. How Wigan compares

4.1 Trend over time

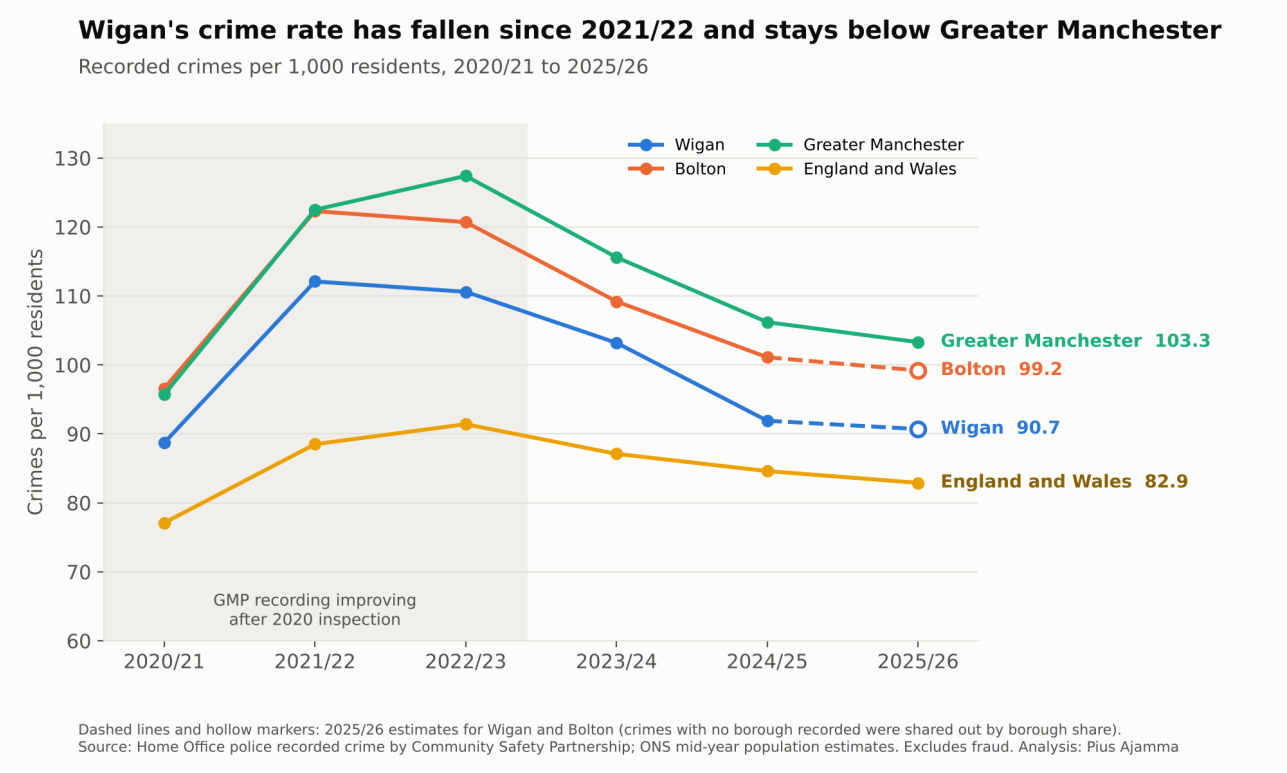


Figure 2. Recorded crimes per 1,000 residents. 2025/26 values for Wigan and Bolton are estimates.

Area	2020/21	2021/22	2022/23	2023/24	2024/25	2025/26
Wigan	88.7	112.1	110.6	103.2	91.9	90.7*
Bolton	96.6	122.3	120.7	109.2	101.1	99.2*
Greater Manchester	95.7	122.5	127.4	115.6	106.2	103.3
England and Wales	77.1	88.5	91.4	87.1	84.6	82.9

*Table 3. Crimes per 1,000 residents, excluding fraud. *Estimate with unassigned crimes shared out (published figures 85.3 and 93.3 are understated).*

Wigan stays below Greater Manchester and Bolton throughout. Its rate fell 18% from the 2021/22 peak to 2024/25, compared with 4% nationally, and its gap above the national rate narrowed from 21% (2022/23) to 9% (2024/25).

This is consistent with independent reports. GMP reported falls in residential burglary (24%) and personal robbery (21%) across Wigan and Leigh in 2025 [10], and Wigan Today reported a 5% fall in recorded crime in the year to September 2025 [11]. A later report of a small rise in the year to December 2025 [9] covers the period when crimes began to go unassigned (section 3), so short-term movements in published borough figures from late 2025 should be read with caution.

4.2 Recording practice in Greater Manchester: an important caveat

In December 2020, HM Inspectorate of Constabulary (HMICFRS) reported that GMP had failed to record an estimated **80,100 crimes** in the year to June 2020: about one in five reported crimes and one in four violent crimes (GMP recorded 77.7% of reported crime) [12]. Under-recording was worst for violent crime, including domestic abuse, harassment, stalking and coercive control. GMP was placed in special measures in December 2020 [13] and removed in October 2022, when inspectors found it compliant with national crime recording standards, recording about 30,500 crimes a month [14][15]. A December 2023 inspection rated no area inadequate [16].

> **Implication:** part of the rise in recorded crime across Greater Manchester between 2020/21 and 2022/23, especially in violence and public order offences, is likely to reflect better recording rather than more crime. Covid-19 lockdowns also lowered crime nationally in 2020/21. Comparisons from 2022/23 onwards are the most reliable. As a cross-check, this analysis finds GMP recorded 371,708 crimes (excluding fraud) in 2022/23, about 31,000 a month, consistent with the inspectorate's figure.

4.3 Greater Manchester ranking

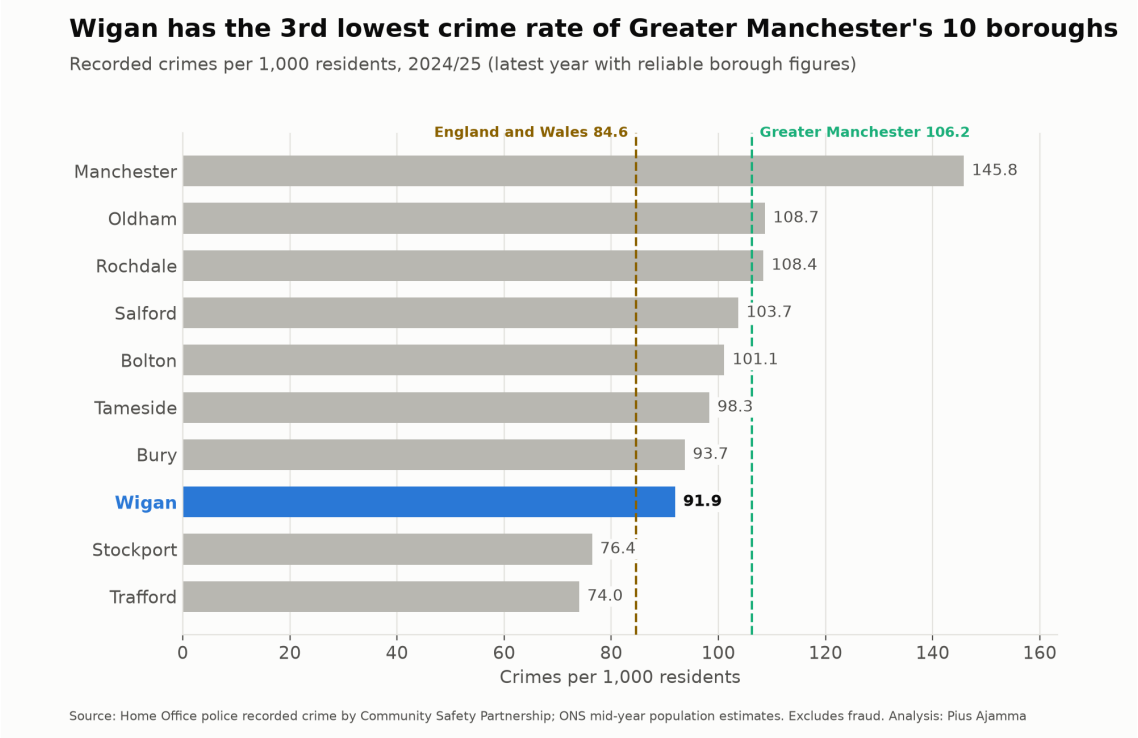


Figure 3. Greater Manchester boroughs, 2024/25.

Rank	Borough	Crimes	Per 1,000 (2024/25)	2025/26 estimate
1	Manchester	85,842	145.8	142.6
2	Oldham	27,245	108.7	105.7
3	Rochdale	25,455	108.4	103.9
4	Salford	30,450	103.7	104.0
5	Bolton	31,243	101.1	99.2
6	Tameside	23,492	98.3	96.1
7	Bury	18,572	93.7	91.7
8	Wigan	31,624	91.9	90.7
9	Stockport	23,079	76.4	74.0
10	Trafford	17,730	74.0	75.5

Table 4. Rank is by 2024/25 rate (1 = highest). The 2025/26 estimate shares out unassigned crimes; Wigan stays 8th.

Counts and rates can tell different stories. Wigan Today reported in May 2026 that Wigan recorded the second-highest number of crimes in Greater Manchester [9]. That is correct as a count, but Wigan is also Greater Manchester's second-largest borough, with about 347,000 residents in mid-2025 [18]. Per resident, it has the third-lowest rate of the ten boroughs. This difference between counts and rates is a likely reason why public perception and recorded crime rates can disagree.

4.4 Types of crime

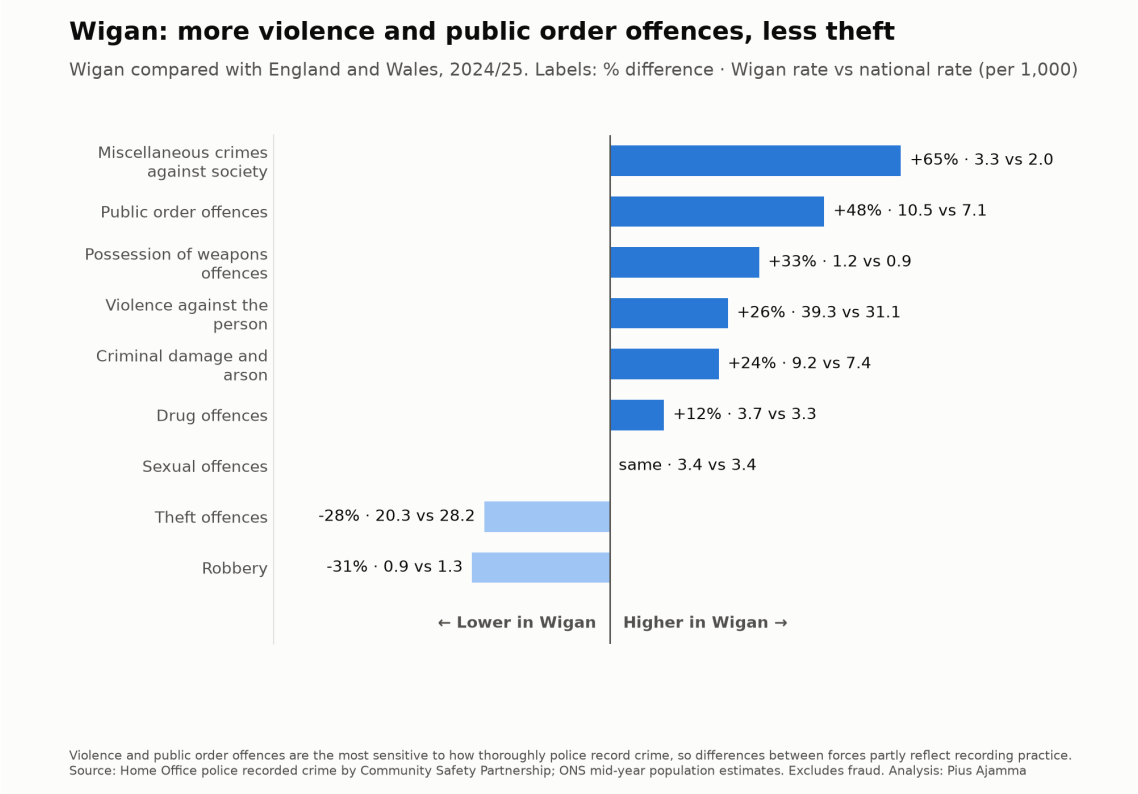


Figure 4. Wigan compared with England and Wales by offence group, 2024/25.

Offence group	Wigan	Bolton	Greater Manchester	England and Wales	Wigan vs E&W
Violence against the person	39.3	42.6	41.6	31.1	1.26×
Theft offences	20.3	24.8	28.4	28.2	0.72×
Public order offences	10.5	11.5	12.0	7.1	1.48×
Criminal damage and arson	9.2	8.3	8.8	7.4	1.24×
Drug offences	3.7	4.3	5.2	3.3	1.12×
Sexual offences	3.4	3.7	4.0	3.4	1.00×
Miscellaneous crimes against society	3.3	3.1	3.1	2.0	1.65×
Possession of weapons	1.2	1.5	1.6	0.9	1.33×
Robbery	0.9	1.4	1.5	1.3	0.69×

Table 5. Crimes per 1,000 residents by offence group, 2024/25.

Wigan is above the national rate for violence, public order and criminal damage, and well below it for theft and robbery. It is below the Greater Manchester average in almost every group; the exceptions are criminal damage (9.2 vs 8.8) and miscellaneous crimes (3.3 vs 3.1). Because violence and public order are the categories most sensitive to recording practice, the differences from the national rate should be read alongside section 4.2.

5. Is Wigan high for a place like it?

A reviewer's strongest objection to section 4 is: *Wigan is more deprived than England as a whole, and deprivation goes with higher crime, so being above average may be expected.* Wigan ranks 102nd of 296 English areas on income deprivation (23.9% of residents on low incomes) and 78th on the overall index, placing it in the more deprived third. This section tests the objection in three steps.

Method

- Crime (2024/25), population (mid-2024) and income deprivation were joined for every English local authority. Names were standardised to match, and districts that merged since the crime file was set up (for example Aylesbury Vale and others into Buckinghamshire) were combined.
- Forces with more than 5% of crime unassigned were excluded (Kent 35.1%, Humberside 12.0%). For other forces, unassigned crime was shared out within the force. A looser rule than section 3 is acceptable here because rates across England range from about 40 to over 150 per 1,000, so a correction of a few percent barely moves any area.
- 250 of 296 areas were analysed (City of London and the Isles of Scilly were dropped for tiny populations). Areas not matched are mainly in Kent and Humberside, and some multi-district crime areas in Devon, Worcestershire and Suffolk.
- An ordinary least squares line of crime rate on income deprivation gives each area's **expected** rate. The gap between actual and expected shows whether an area has more or less crime than its deprivation predicts.

Results: how the answer changed with each fairer comparison

Step	Comparison	Wigan expected	Wigan actual	Gap
1	Raw: England and Wales average	84.6	91.9	+9%
2a	All 250 English areas, line through all	85.8	92.5	+7.7%
2b	All areas, without the 10 highest-rate areas (city centres)	82.0	92.5	+12.8%
2c	15 areas most similar on income deprivation (median)	82.7	92.5	+11.9%
3	36 metropolitan boroughs only (core cities excluded from the line)	88.0	92.5	+5.1%

Table 6. Step 2b: R^2 = 0.62, 2.4 more crimes per 1,000 for each extra 1% on low incomes. Step 3: R^2 = 0.33, slope 1.5.

Controlling for deprivation alone does not explain Wigan's gap; it makes it slightly larger (step 2). Removing city centres, where visitors and commuters inflate per-resident rates, improved the fit sharply (R^2 from 0.35 to 0.62). But many of Wigan's deprivation "peers" are rural or small-town districts (Fenland, Bolsover, the Isle of Wight, Rossendale), which have low crime simply because they are rural. Restricting the comparison to the 36 metropolitan boroughs, large urban areas like Wigan, reduces the gap to +5%.

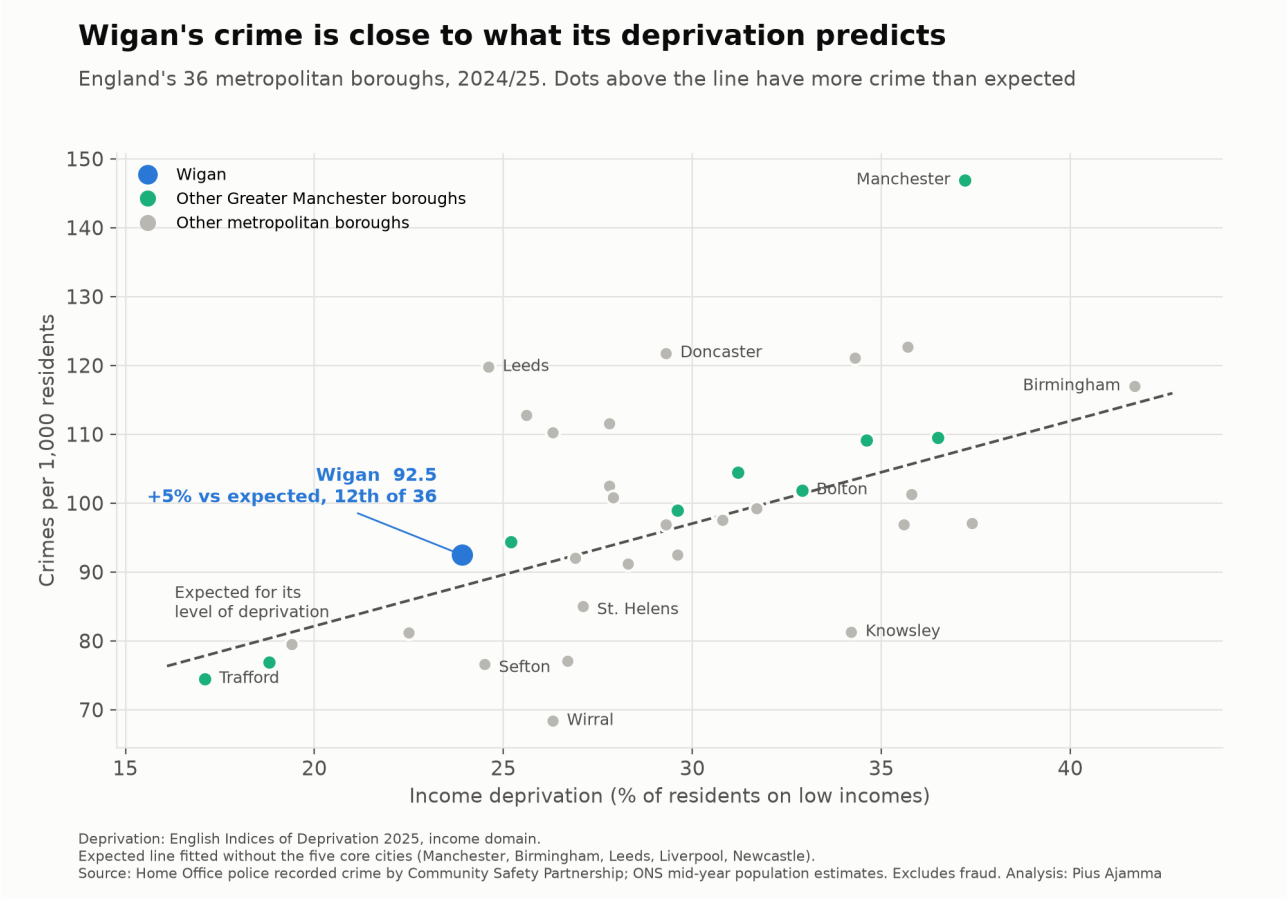


Figure 5. Crime against income deprivation for England's 36 metropolitan boroughs, 2024/25.

Among metropolitan boroughs, Wigan ranks 12th of 36 on the gap from expected, and its raw rate (92.5) is below the metropolitan median (98.3). The spread runs from Manchester (+36%) and Leeds (+35%) to Knowsley (−21%) and Wirral (−25%), so +5% is well within normal variation.

Police force effects

The biggest differences line up with police force boundaries rather than individual places. After allowing for deprivation, the median area in each force ranges from +27% (Avon and Somerset) and +26% (West Yorkshire) to −24% (West Mercia) and −26% (Norfolk). GMP's median is +7.6%. Neighbouring boroughs in different forces differ more than boroughs in the same force: West and South Yorkshire boroughs sit mostly above the line, Merseyside and West Midlands boroughs mostly below, and most GMP boroughs sit between 0% and +6% in the metropolitan comparison. This is consistent with differences in how forces record crime, or with genuine regional differences; the data cannot separate the two.

Force (median vs expected)	Gap	Force	Gap
Avon and Somerset	+26.8%	Leicestershire	+3.2%
West Yorkshire	+25.9%	Northamptonshire	+2.3%
Cleveland	+18.7%	Lincolnshire	−15.8%
Devon and Cornwall	+14.4%	Bedfordshire	−16.4%
South Yorkshire	+11.4%	Wiltshire	−17.2%
Greater Manchester	**+7.6%**	West Mercia	−24.2%
Durham / Essex	+6.7% / +6.4%	Norfolk	−26.1%

Table 7. Median gap from the deprivation-expected rate by force (line without the 10 highest-rate areas). Top ten and bottom five forces shown.

Answer to Q3: Wigan's crime rate is above the national average mainly because it is a large urban borough with above-average deprivation. Compared with similar urban boroughs it is close to typical: about 5% above what its deprivation predicts and below the median raw rate.

6. Forecasting

6.1 Approach and why

- **Short series, simple models.** Each borough has 16 clean quarters (2021/22–2024/25). Models with many parameters, such as gradient-boosted trees or neural networks, would memorise so few points. Tree-based models also cannot predict values below those seen in training, which matters when crime is falling. With short seasonal series, exponential smoothing (Holt-Winters) is the standard, well-tested choice (Hyndman and Athanasopoulos, *Forecasting: Principles and Practice*) [20].
- **A baseline to beat.** Seasonal naive (each quarter equals the same quarter last year) is included so any gain from a cleverer model is measured, not assumed.
- **Time-ordered splits only.** A random train/test split would put future quarters into training (data leakage). All tests train on earlier quarters and predict later ones; the code checks this automatically.
- **2020/21 excluded** from training: it combines Covid lockdowns with GMP's under-recording period. Older data (2015/16–2019/20) was deliberately not used for the same reason.
- **No scaling.** Each model sees one borough's series on its own, and the models used give identical forecasts with or without rescaling. The normalisation that matters, per 1,000 residents, is applied after forecasting.

6.2 Choosing a model

A single back-test (train 2021/22–2023/24, predict 2024/25) compared three simple models by mean absolute percentage error (MAPE):

Borough	Seasonal naive	Trend + season (linear)	Holt-Winters (damped, additive)
Bolton	6.6	3.5	2.2
Bury	8.4	6.9	7.1
Manchester	9.9	13.8	1.6
Oldham	5.0	4.8	2.7
Rochdale	2.5	1.7	4.0
Salford	7.1	13.2	3.0
Stockport	10.3	12.7	3.2
Tameside	5.7	4.1	3.6
Trafford	4.2	3.5	18.1
Wigan	10.9	9.0	4.3
Average	**7.1**	**7.3**	**5.0**

Table 8. Back-test error (MAPE, %) predicting 2024/25. The linear trend failed for boroughs whose crime rose then fell (Manchester, Salford, Stockport).

A single test year can flatter or punish a model by chance (note Trafford's 18.1%). Six Holt-Winters designs were therefore compared with **rolling-origin cross-validation**: forecasts from six successive starting points (training ending 2023/24 Q2 through 2024/25 Q3), giving 18

predictions per borough, with no data after March 2025.

Design	Average	Median	Worst borough	Boroughs won
HW damped trend, multiplicative season	6.0	6.4	10.1	2
HW damped trend, additive season	6.2	6.4	9.9	2
HW no trend, additive season	6.3	6.2	8.7	1
HW no trend, multiplicative season	6.4	6.5	8.7	1
HW trend, multiplicative season	6.5	7.0	12.0	3
HW trend, additive season	7.4	7.8	11.8	0
Seasonal naive (baseline)	7.8	7.3	10.6	1

Table 9. Rolling-origin cross-validation (MAPE, %). Every Holt-Winters design beat the baseline; the top four are within 0.4 points of each other. The single back-test (5.0%) was optimistic; about 6% is the realistic error.

The damped multiplicative design was selected (6.0% average; 6.4% for Wigan). Multiplicative seasonality means each quarter is a percentage above or below normal, so seasonal swings shrink in proportion as crime falls. Damping makes the trend fade instead of continuing indefinitely. In the single back-test, Wigan's damped model learned smoothing parameters of about 0.54 (level and trend), 0.00 (season, meaning a stable seasonal pattern) and 0.87 (damping).

Ensemble

Averaging forecasts from different models is one of the most reliable findings in forecasting research, including the M4 competition (Makridakis et al., 2020) [21]. The damped model assumes the recent fall continues and fades; the no-trend model assumes crime stays level. Weights from 0 to 1 were tested on the same cross-validation, on a fine grid (steps of 0.05) with unrounded errors.

Weight on damped model	0.00	0.25	0.50	0.55	0.75	1.00
Average error (%)	6.36	5.84	5.55	5.54	5.68	6.02

Table 10. The combination beats either model alone. The optimum (0.55) was used; it is 0.01 points better than an equal mix, consistent with the "forecast combination puzzle" that tuned weights rarely beat equal ones by much [22].

On the 2024/25 back-test the single model and the ensemble tied (5.1% each), but the ensemble cut the worst borough error by a third (Trafford 18.4% to 12.4%). The single model leaned low (−0.8%) and the ensemble high (+1.6%) in a year when crime fell; the reverse was true in 2025/26 when crime levelled off. Because the direction of the next change is unknown, the ensemble is used for forward forecasts.

Disclosure. The ensemble was added after observing that the original model under-predicted when crime levelled off in 2025/26. Its cross-validation score uses only data to March 2025, but because the idea came from viewing later data, its 2025/26 performance is not treated as an independent test. The single damped model, chosen before 2025/26 was examined, is the primary out-of-sample result.

6.3 Out-of-sample test: 2025/26

The selected model was trained on 2021/22–2024/25 and forecast 2025/26 without seeing it. Borough figures for 2025/26 are understated (section 3), but GMP's force total is complete, because unassigned crimes are still counted. That makes the force total a fair test.

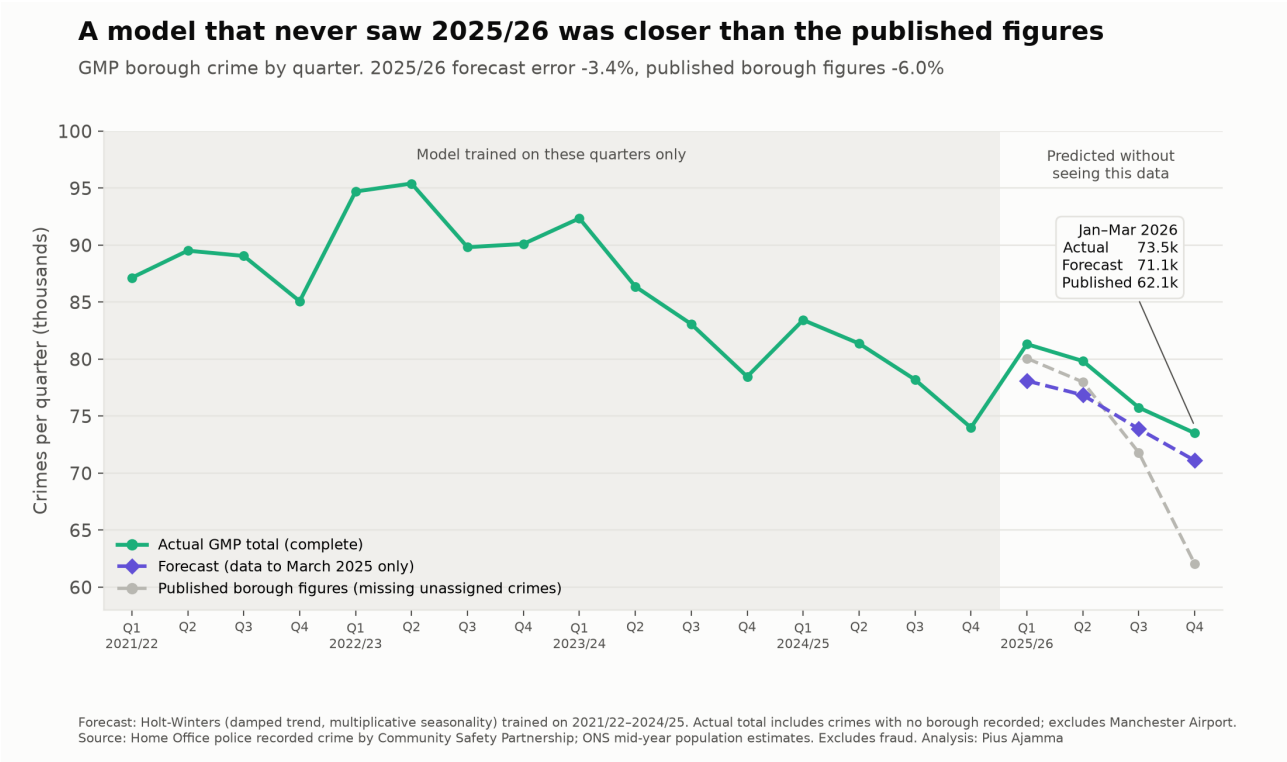


Figure 6. GMP borough crime by quarter: actual (complete), forecast, and published borough figures.

2025/26	Actual (complete)	Forecast	Error	Published boroughs	Error
Q1 (Apr–Jun)	81,321	78,102	−4.0%	80,073	−1.5%
Q2 (Jul–Sep)	79,839	76,857	−3.7%	78,003	−2.3%
Q3 (Oct–Dec)	75,758	73,880	−2.5%	71,808	−5.2%
Q4 (Jan–Mar)	73,517	71,117	−3.3%	62,052	−15.6%
Year	**310,435**	**299,956**	**−3.4%**	**291,936**	**−6.0%**

Table 11. Single damped model trained to March 2025. Actual excludes Manchester Airport. The ensemble's error for the year was −2.3%.

The forecast stayed within the cross-validation error, with a steady under-prediction rather than drift: crime fell, but less than the 2024/25 trend implied. For April–September 2025, when few crimes were unassigned, borough forecasts averaged 3.0% error (Wigan −0.9%).

Wigan 2025/26	Crimes	Per 1,000	vs England and Wales (82.9)
Published (understated)	29,611	85.3	1.03×
Single model forecast	30,487	87.8	1.06×
Ensemble forecast	31,072	89.5	1.08×
Unassigned crimes shared out	31,487	90.7	1.09×

Table 12. Two independent methods, one using 2025/26 data and one not, agree that Wigan's 2025/26 rate was about 6–9% above England and Wales, as in 2024/25.

6.4 How far ahead can this be trusted?

A two-year test at force level (train 2021/22–2023/24, predict 2024/25 and 2025/26) measured how error grows:

	Year 1 error	Year 2 error	Direction
Holt-Winters (damped, multiplicative)	3.0%	7.2%	Under-predicted every quarter
Seasonal naive	7.2%	9.5%	–

Table 13. Error more than doubles in year 2. A simulated 90% interval covered all 8 quarters but was too wide to be useful (about ±24% and ±68%), so measured errors are used instead.

Horizon	Verdict	How it is presented
1 year (2026/27)	Reliable	Forecast ±3%
2 years (2027/28)	Usable	Forecast ±7%
3–5 years (to 2030/31)	Not a prediction	Scenarios: trend continues vs levels off; band widened ~4 points a year (indicative)

6.5 Forward forecast

Forward forecasts use GMP's force total, which is complete up to June 2026 (21 quarters), then take Wigan's share. Wigan's share of borough crime has been stable at 10.0–10.6% (10.57%, 10.04%, 10.34%, 10.05% in 2021/22–2024/25); the mean of the last two years, 10.20%, is used. Rates assume Wigan's population keeps growing at its 2020–2025 average of 1.15% a year.

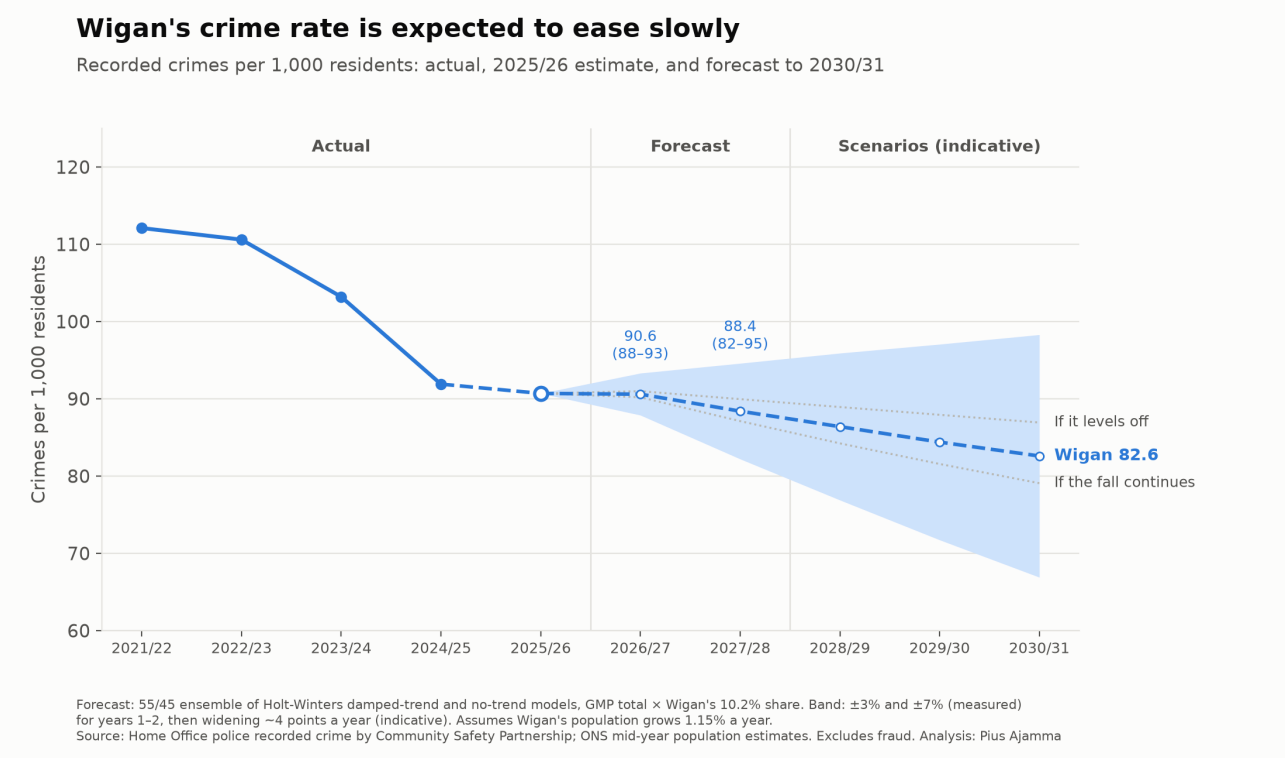


Figure 7. Wigan: actual, 2025/26 estimate, and forecast to 2030/31.

Year	Type	GMP total	Wigan crimes	Wigan per 1,000	Range (per 1,000)
2026/27	Forecast	311,829	31,791	90.6	87.8–93.3 (±3%)
2027/28	Forecast	307,865	31,389	88.4	82.2–94.6 (±7%)
2028/29	Scenario	304,215	31,017	86.4	Scenarios 84.2–88.9
2029/30	Scenario	300,854	30,672	84.4	Scenarios 81.6–87.9
2030/31	Scenario	297,761	30,357	82.6	Scenarios 79.1–86.9

Table 14. Ensemble forecast (55% damped, 45% no trend). Scenario ranges show the gap between the two assumptions, not full uncertainty, which is at least as wide as year 2.

Two cautions. Counts barely fall (about 1% a year); much of the falling *rate* comes from the assumed population growth. And 82.6 in 2030/31 should not be compared with today's national

rate, because the national rate will also change and has not been forecast.

6.6 A prospective test

The forecast was saved on 22 October 2026, before the next release. The January 2027 Home Office release will add July–September 2026. **The forecast for GMP's total that quarter is 79,841** (expected within about ±3%, roughly 77,400–82,200). This is a test nobody has seen the answer to, and the result will be published alongside this report. If the Home Office later reassigns the unassigned crimes, Wigan's true 2025/26 figure will also become a direct test of the estimates in Table 12.

7. Limitations

Limitation	Effect	How it was handled
Recorded crime is not actual crime	Depends on reporting and police recording	Same-force comparisons favoured; recording caveat stated; cross-force differences treated with caution
No street-level or time-of-day data for GMP	Cannot assess the town centre or night-time	Stated as out of scope; borough level only
Unassigned crimes from late 2025	2025/26 borough figures understated	2024/25 used for comparison; 2025/26 estimated two ways
Sharing out unassigned crimes assumes they resemble assigned ones	Estimates could be biased if not	Not yet tested (offence mix of unassigned crimes could be compared)
GMP recording changes 2020–2022	Inflates the 2021–23 rise	Shaded on charts; comparisons from 2022/23 preferred
Short series (16–21 quarters)	Wide uncertainty; overlapping test windows	Simple models; baseline; rolling CV; measured error bands
Choices made after viewing results	Optimistic evaluation of the ensemble	Disclosed; single model kept as primary result
Wigan forecast uses a fixed share	Share variation (±3%) not in the band	Share shown to be stable; noted
Population growth assumed	Affects future rates	Stated; counts shown alongside rates
Deprivation comparison excludes Kent, Humberside and some districts	Mostly rural, less deprived areas missing	Metropolitan comparison unaffected
Fraud and anti-social behaviour excluded	Not a complete picture of harm	Standard practice; stated in definitions

8. Conclusions

- **Q1.** Wigan's recorded crime rate (91.9 per 1,000 in 2024/25) is above the national average, below the Greater Manchester average, the 3rd lowest of the ten boroughs, and has fallen faster than the national rate since 2021/22.
- **Q2.** The difference from the national rate comes from violence, public order and criminal damage. Theft and robbery are well below average. These are also the categories most affected by GMP's recording improvements.
- **Q3.** Compared with similar urban, similarly deprived boroughs, Wigan is close to typical (+5%, 12th of 36). The largest differences between places follow police force boundaries.
- **Q4.** A model trained before 2025/26 predicted GMP's total to within 3.4%. Wigan's rate is expected to ease slowly: about 90.6 in 2026/27 and 88.4 in 2027/28. Beyond two years only scenarios are justified.

Two data problems were found along the way: GMP's absence from police.uk since 2019, and the collapse of borough coding in late 2025. Both limit what residents can find out about crime where they live. Raising the second with the Home Office crime statistics team, or through a Freedom of Information request to GMP, would help establish its cause.

9. Reproducibility

All code is published at https://github.com/dynamixAI/wigan-crime-analysis. One command (./run_pipeline.sh) downloads the pinned sources, converts them, and reruns every stage: data preparation, rates and rankings, the deprivation comparison, model selection, the 2025/26 test, the forward forecast and all charts. The download stage records a SHA-256 checksum of each file, so you can tell if a source has since been revised. The fitted forecasting models are saved, with a model card listing their parameters, training data, ensemble weight and the next check due. A test runs the whole pipeline on synthetic data with the same file layouts.

Note: ONS population estimates and Home Office tables are revised over time, so rerunning later may give slightly different figures. The checksums show whether that is the cause.

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Glossary

Term	Meaning
CSP	Community Safety Partnership; the area crime is published for, usually the same as the council area
Per 1,000	Crimes divided by residents, times 1,000; allows areas of different sizes to be compared
Unassigned	Crimes GMP recorded without a borough
MAPE	Mean absolute percentage error: on average, how far forecasts missed, in %
Holt-Winters	Exponential smoothing that tracks level, trend and seasonality, weighting recent data more
Damped trend	A trend that fades over time instead of continuing forever
Rolling-origin CV	Testing a forecast from several successive starting points, never using later data to predict earlier
Ensemble	A weighted average of forecasts from more than one model
R^2	Share of the differences between areas explained by the line (0 to 1)